

Deewar

(1973, Colour)

Yash Chopra's film remains an enduring favourite, chiefly for its powerful storyline by Salim-Javed, who took Hindi cinema to new heights from the early 1970s onwards. In films by this famous writing duo, Amitabh Bachchan deservedly cemented his long and illustrious career—and *Deewar* is among the star's most commanding performances. Inspired by *Mother India* and *Ganga Jumna*, the film's story moves from village to city and, like the earlier classics, centres around two brothers on opposite sides of the law. The strength of Salim Khan's screenplay and Javed Akhtar's memorable dialogue make this an all-time great.



changed what was expected of the hero—to his many attributes, humour was added as an integral part, and so *Amar Akbar Anthony* was unwittingly instrumental in phasing out the role of the comedian. In one scene, we see Amitabh Bachchan fighting, in another he has us in splits.



Devdas

(1955, B&W)

Based on Sarat Chandra Chatterjee's Bengali novel, the story of Devdas has obsessed generations of filmmakers, resulting in over 15 filmed versions in various Indian languages. For me, Bimal Roy's reimagining of the life of this flawed hero, unable to go against societal pressures and marry his childhood sweetheart, is the subtlest by far. Suchitra Sen as Paro, Vyjayanthimala as Chandramukhi, are superb, while Dilip Kumar brings an emotional truth rarely seen in Hindi cinema to his character. His silent presence is matched by Bimal Roy's cinematic eloquence. Together, they remind us of the saying, "Less is more."